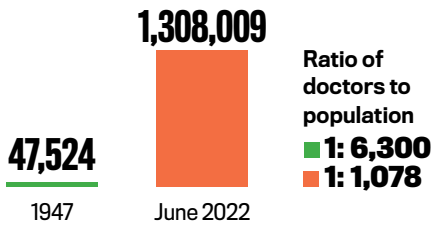
HOW MANY DOCTORS DO WE HAVE?

TOTAL NO. OF ALLOPATHIC DOCTORS



1: 1,000
WHO STANDARD

565,000
Ayush doctors
Total doctor-population ratio: **1: 854****

**Source: National Medicine Council of India/UN data-based population figures; ** including Ayush doctors*

NURSE STATION

1947 **7,000**
Total number of nurses

June 2022
3,398,160**
Total number of nurses

*Estimated figures **Includes 1,000,805 nurse associates and 56,854 lady health visitors

Dentist-population ratio
1.96: 1,000

3: 1,000
WHO STANDARD

612
Total number of medical colleges



GETTY IMAGES

MY FRIEND
The 'Mitra' robot assistant on call for a patient at a Noida Covid hospital, 2020

the heart of the infrastructure—running the hardware. February 1835 saw India's first initiates into modern medicine: a batch of 50 young men at Calcutta Medical College, set to study on a stipend of Rs 7-12 each. By 1947, with 19 medical schools, India had a mere 47,000 doctors for its hundreds of millions—1 for every 6,300 people. It took 75 years for us to inch close to the WHO-mandated ratio of 1:1,000, with over 1.3 million doctors. This is not counting the world's second highest number of dentists—270,000 as of June 2022. But overall numbers don't ensure accessibility and quality. Rural India, home to 60 per cent of our population, had a *78 per cent* shortfall of physicians in 2019. Nursing is also in deficit: 3.4 million personnel means less than two nurses for every 1,000 Indians, well short of WHO's golden ratio of 3:1,000. This situation of want is what leads to concerns over the mental health of healthcare workers, as evidenced by the 'I am Overworked' campaign by Indian doctors in 2019—one year *before* the pandemic. The resilience we saw thereafter calls for a million salutes. ■